

GARY CHAPIN SERVICE

02/28/20

(Thank the people for coming to the memorial service)

(Thank the people for the floral arrangements and acts of kindness)

(Thank the family for the opportunity to participate in the memorial service of such an AWESOME man – Bro. Chapin felt the word AWESOME was way overused but I am going to use it repeatedly today, and in my opinion, it is completely appropriate in this setting)

Susan and I have had the wonderful distinction of being Brother and Sister Chapin's pastors for almost Nineteen years. In that time, they have been some of the best church members a pastor could ask for. They led our Wednesday night traditional service for almost ten years. (Have

those who attend his Wednesday night service to stand)

Brother Chapin was a devout Christian; a dedicated family man; a committed minister of the Gospel; and one of the most principled men of character I have ever known.

A little after 2:00 this past Sunday morning Bro. Chapin's room in Heaven was made ready and he traded Houston for Heaven. How fitting that he went to Heaven on Sunday.

When Sister Chapin asked me to preach this memorial service the first Scripture that came to my mind was a little-known passage tucked away in the 23rd chapter of Luke. Interestingly enough, the setting of this passage is the crucifixion of Jesus. The disciples failed to stand with Jesus in His greatest hour of trial. Before going to Pilates judgment hall Jesus predicted that Simon Peter would deny him, an

accusation which Peter vehemently denied. Peter's denial of Jesus was made very public and all of us know about it, but Dr. Luke makes us aware that not only did Peter deny Jesus; all the other disciples *"forsook Him and fled"*.

While Jesus is left all alone to die on the cross, we are introduced to a man whose name has never been in lights, but whose deeds exceed the deeds of the disciples by a long shot.

Luke 23:50-53 *"Now behold, there was a man named Joseph, a council member, a good and just man.⁵¹ He had not consented to their decision and deed. He was from Arimathea, a city of the Jews, who himself was also waiting for the kingdom of God.⁵² This man went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus.⁵³ Then he took it down, wrapped it in linen, and laid it in a tomb that was hewn out of the rock, where no one had ever lain before."*

This Scripture gives us a glimpse into the life of this ***"good man"***: (Today I am going to refer to he and Bro. Chapin as AWESOME MEN). Here is what we know about this AWESOME man in Scripture:

- His name was Joseph
- He lived in Arimathea - ***"A city of the Jews."***
- He was a man who had distinguished himself as a leader - ***"He was a council member."***
- He was respected by his peers - Places of leadership are reserved for people who secure the respect of peers and superiors.
- He did not agree with the decision to convict and crucify Jesus - ***"He had not consented to their decisions and deeds."*** (Bro. Chapin stood on principle – (*"Now, listen to Bro. Chapin"*))
- He was a believer - ***"He was waiting for the Kingdom of God."***

- He was a doer of good deeds - This man went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus. *"Then he took it down, wrapped it in linen, and laid it in a tomb that was hewn out of the rock, where no one had ever lain before."*

In a world where AWESOME men are growing scarcer by the day, Bro. Chapin was an AWESOME man. When I read this Scripture, I asked myself the question, how does one become a good or AWESOME man?

By looking at Joseph's life and Bro. Chapin's life, I have come to the following conclusion; one does not become an AWESOME man by winning a popularity contest or an election; one becomes known as an AWESOME man by the sum total of the deeds which he does.

I. BROTHER CHAPIN WAS AN AWESOME CHRISTIAN GENTLEMAN!

Joseph made a choice to follow Jesus when as far as we know, he was the only one on the council who made this decision. He made this decision when public sentiment was running very high in the opposite direction.

Brother Chapin was a faithful church member:

- He sat on the front row and was entrusted with the microphone...
- He faithfully attended church – They did not miss church except when they were traveling or in the case of being too ill to attend...
- He was a faithful giver – He paid his tithe to CT Church this past Sunday despite the fact that it was his first Sunday in Heaven...
- He was a fierce defender of this church and its leadership team – When the church grew, they stayed – When the church transitioned

through a plethora of changes, they stayed -
When others left, they stayed – As a pastor,
I never once doubted their loyalty to this
church and to me personally...

Brother Chapin made a choice to serve Jesus in
1944! After almost 76 years he was still
devoted to his choice! This street turned to gold
for Brother Chapin on Sunday morning!

Brother Chapin was an AWESOME Christian
gentleman!

II. BROTHER CHAPIN WAS AN AWESOME STUDENT OF THE BIBLE!

Joseph would not have been on the Council
unless he understood civil and religious
complexities!

The creed Brother Chapin decided to live by is the Word of God. His life can be characterized by the Fruit of the Spirit: Love, joy, peace, patience, goodness, kindness, faithfulness, and gentleness. His family has many good memories about this AWESOME man, and this is because he chose to allow his life to be regulated by the boundaries of the Word of God! Brother Chapin left the following words for his family and all of us to follow: *“The book, God’s holy Word, the Bible is always right. Always remember, what does the Book, God’s holy Word, the Bible say?”*

In preaching the Wednesday night traditional service, I noticed that Brother Chapin did not just preach old sermons from years of previous ministry, he was constantly studying out something new. In fact, while they were at Hill Country Camp, just hours before having a stroke, Brother Chapin was working on a new sermon series for Wednesday nights.

Oftentimes after a Sunday morning service I would receive a text from Brother Chapin letting me know he thoroughly enjoyed the sermon and sometimes he would even offer some additional points for consideration

I have chosen one such exchange to share with you. In August 2019, I had been preaching a series on Spiritual Authority and on August 8, at 3:55 PM I received this text from Brother Chapin: *“Pastor: You did an excellent job in your teaching on Spiritual Authority. In my own devotions this morning, I did a little, by no means exhaustive, research on Hebrews 13:17. The way you described it is true, but the account part is two-sided. Not only will the Spiritual Authority give an account of the sheep under his care, but he will give an account of his stewardship in the manner in which he led, taught, treated, interacted with, and cared for those under his leadership. Together that puts a double-weight of accountability upon the shoulders of the Spiritual Authority and what is facing him at the Judgment Seat of Christ. We*

have twice as much responsibility on us as do those under us. When you add to all that our accountability concerning our submission to our Spiritual Authority(ies) over us, it is a big, heavy, responsibility to be entrusted with the position of being a Spiritual Authority. It is extremely dangerous to take that responsibility lightly, trifle with it in any manner, ever misuse it in any manner, or ever misuse it for selfish purposes. Just a few thoughts I gleaned this morning.” Then he left a heart emoji and said, I “I love you.”

Brother Chapin was an AWESOME student of the Bible!

III. BROTHER CHAPIN WAS AN AWESOME HUSBAND!

Though the Bible does not say so, there is little doubt that Joseph had a family, because he

would not have been permitted to serve on the Council if he was not a good family man!

Brother Chapin was married Sister Chapin on March 26, 1960! Almost 60 years! (I can't call them Gary & Annese – They are Brother and Sister Chapin to me – I even have them in my phone as Brother Chapin and Sister Chapin – He called himself Brother Chapin and his wife Sister Chapin – I can't call them anything else)

This couple was committed to each other in a way this generation can hardly understand. They were inseparable:

- Cultural problems could not separate them...
- Financial problems could not separate them...
- Health problems could not separate them...

- The opinions of others could not separate them...

...nothing but death could separate them!

Brother and Sister Chapin are the kind of people who make choices and then stand by them, no matter what!

I would have voted Brother and Sister Chapin the "*most likely to succeed!*"

Brother Chapin was an AWESOME husband!

IV. BROTHER CHAPIN WAS AN AWESOME FATHER AND GRANDFATHER!

The family of Brother Chapin would tell you that Brother Chapin was a very opinionated man. Though he was an opinionated man he was not an obnoxious man.

Brother Chapin used his strong opinions to teach his children and grandchildren many good life lessons:

- He taught them that life is not a spectator sport; it is a full contact sport...
- He taught them to stand on principle...
- He taught them to love God, family and the church... (No bitter preacher's kids here)
- He taught them the value of making a living... (He was a good provider and a hard-working man)

The Lord healed Brother Chapin in 2008, when he was too sick to live. God gave him twelve more years and in that time he and Sister Chapin became grandparents, the greatest fraternity on earth.

Brother Chapin was an AWESOME father and grandfather.

V. BROTHER CHAPIN MADE AN AWESOME DECISION TO PURSUE MINISTRY!

Joseph was a deeply religious man and placed himself in a spot of civil and religious authority.

Brother Chapin has been an Ordained minister in the Assemblies of God for many years. He served as:

- Children's Pastor
- Youth Pastor
- Christian Education Director
- Sectional Presbyter
- General Presbyter
- Camp Chairman
- Executive Secretary Treasurer
- Lead Pastor – In Alabama, Minnesota & Texas

He was elected to be the Pastor of a church a month before he and Sister Chapin married in 1960, and was still pastoring people when he

moved from Houston to Heaven. (Story of him preaching the Wednesday night traditional service – He pastored those people)

Brother Chapin was respected and elected by his peers to many leadership positions within the Assemblies of God. The last post he held was Executive Secretary Treasurer of the South Texas District of the Assemblies of God, where he served with dignity and honor for 16 years.

Brother Chapin was far more than a religious bureaucrat; he was a friend of those who found themselves in a difficult spot. A young minister shared a story with me just a few days ago about being placed on discipline and then receiving an encouraging card, and a \$100 check from Brother and Sister Chapin every month.

Brother Chapin was an AWESOME minister!

CONCLUSION:

Brother Chapin never considered failure. He believed that God would give him the strength and ability to get the job done. He was an AWESOME man, and because of his confidence in his standing and relationship with God, he was comfortable with who he was, and where he was. He was courageous until the very end.

Brother Chapin left the following quotes behind to be read at his service: *“If you hear that Gary Chapin died, don’t you believe a word of it! I’m more alive than I have ever been. I’ve just changed addresses.”* According to John 14: 2-3 ***“In my Fathers house are many mansions,: If it were not so I would have told you. I Go to prepare a place for you. 3 And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am you may be also.”*** Brother Chapin continued by saying *“My room in Heaven was ready, so He came and got me, and took me to Heaven! Wow! You ought to see this place. It’s everything*

you've heard, and read about, and so much more. You'll love it! It is worth it all! I'm waiting for you. I can hardly wait for us to be reunited again – forever!" 1 Corinthians 2:9-10
"It is written, eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither has it entered into the heart of man, the things which God has prepared for them that love Him. 10 But God has revealed them to us by His Spirit; for the Spirit searches all things, yes, the deep things of God."

Brother Chapin said, *"I trust that I have lived my life in such a way that it can be said of me, A man of God and His Word has lived among us."*

I close with one of Bro Chapin's favorite scriptures, John 11:25-26 – Jesus' dialogue with the sister of Lazarus – ***"Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection and the life: He that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live. 26 And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die."***

(Give altar call)

